

Comment:

"In a online meeting with one of the researchers it was stated that the intervention was not implemented by the researchers and could be seen as mandatory new developments based on national and international rules and regulations. Therefore, this study is simply evaluating the current state of online gambling. However, after reading this section I still feel a bit uneasy about this. Terminology like 'proof of concept' feels like we are testing something, that is not 'treatment as usual'. Furthermore, the following section also raised some eyebrows 'NB: the unique impact of RG tools (i.e., tool efficacy) will not be assessed at this stage, as the focus of the POC evaluation look at the system of RG tools acting in concert rather than on individual RG measures alone. Further, given the naturalistic setting and the constraints deriving from online gambling regulations, a controlled design comparing the POC version to the RG tools currently implemented by operators (i.e., treatment as usual) was considered not feasible.' Apparently, something new and experimental is implemented and evaluated. Would this new version of RG tools also have been implemented if this was not evaluated by this or some other study? It still feels a bit like a new intervention that needs to be evaluated and therefore there are risks involved for online gamblers that differ from TAU."

Response:

The gambling operator is implementing the RG tools, and the initial comment is correct – the RG tools that will be implemented (over and above how RG tools are currently deployed online by operators) will be aligned to, as said, *"mandatory new developments based on national and international legal regulations and policies"*.

An integral part of the gambling operator meeting these requirements also includes efforts to evaluate the impact of RG tools offered to gamblers (e.g., by trial and evaluation of different approaches). Such tools include all types of RG messaging or other tools (e.g., limiters, cooling-off periods, "reality checks") that operators implement on gambling websites to support and guide players' behaviour towards RG practices. Furthermore, regulators have issued advice that to the best of an operator's ability, RG tools should be based on the level of gambling risk – from automated pop-up messages to spending limiters, etc. – and adapt messaging towards the most optimal outcome (i.e., preventing risk escalation, which is different from preventing clinical harm, out of scope of this project). Taken together, our collaboration with the operators and the resulting project design looks to satisfy the regulators' requirements for online RG measures. We will support the design of tailored RG tools that the operator would, in any case, try to upscale and assess anyway. However, as opposed to the operators making changes to each RG tool one by one, we are supporting a full systems approach derived from scientific evidence and theory, guiding the operator's efforts to scale and deliver the range of RG tools they already possess. Moreover, operators are already required to evaluate RG, but in this case, we can support their efforts with systematic and rigorous research and statistical methods.

In response to the more specific points of concern (i.e., the quoted section), the terminology used was to explain why it is not possible, nor desirable to have 2 groups when working in a naturalistic setting. First, by proof of concept we mean a 'small-scale' version of the tailored RG framework. At this stage, we (along with the operators) want to ensure that how RG tools are tailored to risk level (as the regulator has advised) is feasible and

acceptable to gamblers. Hence, deploying a first, simpler version is wiser and cost-effective (also due to development and implementation costs).

Second, we think the use of the term TAU has mislead the ERB reviewers. The RG tool standards operators deploy and need to comply with continually evolve within the online gambling environment as regulations are updated. It is simply not possible to split the whole player base of an operator to 2 groups, one receiving the current (or “old” version of RG tools, aka what we could consider a “TAU”) to a newer, updated, better functioning version of RG tools. Having 100000 customers receiving something deemed suboptimal (ie, the current or old RG tools, aka TAU) would not be compliant to regulations and was also not deemed ethical by the research team. To reply to the last question in the comment, yes, the new version of RG tools that we will co-design and revise (based on the existing ones and the available evidence in the field combined with theory) will be implemented and tested in any case. By sharing their data for scientific purposes, which is the only aspect gamblers can consent to, gamblers do not incur in any additional risk other than the risk they incur when deciding to gamble online.